



Q I'm so tired all the time. How can I get enough rest to feel refreshed?

Fatigue is inevitable in pregnancy. During the first trimester, it is caused largely by your body's effort to nourish your developing embryo, and a massive surge in progesterone. During the last trimester, it's the result of the general discomfort of carrying an ever-growing baby. However, there are techniques you can use to minimize fatigue.

Scale back

A busy social life is fantastic when you aren't pregnant, but during pregnancy you may need to be more selective about what you do. Try to cut back on events that are going to require very late bedtimes or long periods of time on your feet. Don't be afraid to cancel plans if you feel too tired to attend—your friends will understand. Figure out what your social limits are and work within them. Scale back on your chores, too—consider getting groceries delivered, for example.

Don't toss and turn

If you wake up in the night and can't get back to sleep, do something quiet but positive, rather than lying there ruminating. Keep a pen and paper beside your bed and write down a to-do list for the following day; read a few pages of a book; take a short walk to the bathroom and back. You could even listen to some soothing night music through headphones (quietly) to give your mind something else to focus on.

Support your legs

Place a cushion between them.



WAYS TO HELP YOU SLEEP



Nap

Give your body (and brain) a chance to recuperate. If you're working, be unabashed about taking a nap at lunchtime (this is easiest if you have your own office, but a lounge may work). On the weekends, set an alarm for a 50-minute nap. This will give you five minutes to fall asleep, but should wake you during your lightest sleep stage (see top right for explanation on sleep cycles), so that you don't feel groggy.



Rest

Even if you can't have a full nap during the day, make sure you make time to rest. That means, sitting comfortably in a chair with your eyes closed. According to research, being fully at rest and with your eyes closed is almost as restful as sleep itself. If you're at work, put some earphones in and listen to some music that you find deeply relaxing, or even simply take earplugs to block out the white noise around you.



Rehydration

Dehydration compounds the effects of feeling tired, making you feel even more drained and lethargic. It's really important that you keep up your fluid intake every day. You don't need to drink more than nonpregnant people, but you do need to make sure you drink enough, which is around 74 fluid ounces (2.2 liters) of fluid a day.



Food

Your body is best at sleeping when it is relaxed. If you have a light dinner, not later than 8 pm, by the time you go to bed a couple of hours later the hard work of digestion will be over and your body can concentrate on sleeping rather than digesting. See p.57 for advice on how to distribute your meals and snacks throughout the day.